



United States
Attorney's Office
Southern District of West Virginia



Putnam County Veterinarian Ordered to Pay \$956,709 in Civil Penalties

Tuesday, August 5, 2025

For Immediate Release

U.S. Attorney's Office, Southern District of
West Virginia

CHARLESTON, W.Va. – The United States Attorney's Office for the Southern District of West Virginia secured a \$956,709 default judgment against Clara Ann Mason, a Putnam County veterinarian, after she was unable to account for 9,796 dosage units of oxycodone HCL, hydrocodone/acetaminophen and other controlled substances, Acting United States Attorney Lisa G. Johnston announced today.

United States District Judge Robert C. Chambers ordered Mason, 64, of Winfield, to pay the maximum civil penalties. The Court found that Mason ordered thousands of doses of opioids and other drugs, failed to keep these drugs secured, failed to keep track of these drugs, and apparently fabricated records to cover her failures.

According to court documents, between March 8, 2018, and July 10, 2023, Mason ordered 14,200 dosage units of hydrocodone/acetaminophen at 10/325 milligrams each, 800 dosage units of oxycodone HCL at 10 milligrams each, and 600 dosage units of oxycodone HCL at 5 milligrams each from a veterinary pharmaceutical wholesale supplier. At the time, Mason was licensed under the laws of West Virginia to practice veterinary medicine and was registered with the Drug Enforcement Administration (DEA) as a practitioner authorized to dispense controlled substances to the extent permitted by federal law.

For the years 2021, 2022, and 2023, Mason ordered substantially more hydrocodone/acetaminophen from the supplier than any other individual customer. Between January 2021 and January 2023, Mason's oxycodone HCL orders accounted for 74 percent of all oxycodone HCL dosage units sold by the supplier.

On October 11, 2023, investigators executed an administrative inspection warrant at the address Mason registered with DEA in Winfield and found controlled substances unsecured in numerous locations throughout the property. During the execution of the warrant, Mason was unable to produce any records of dispensing scheduled medications, the required DEA forms recording her purchases of controlled

substances, or inventory records also required by federal law. Mason voluntarily surrendered her DEA registration number during the execution of the warrant.

Investigators took possession of all controlled substances found during the execution of the warrant and determined that at least 6,593 dosage units of hydrocodone and oxycodone were unaccounted for along with other controlled substances. In the days and weeks following the execution of the warrant, Mason provided purported records alleging she dispensed large quantities of opioids to dogs and cats prior to euthanasia. Investigators believe these documents were largely fabricated. Investigators also interviewed several pet owners, and none said they witnessed Mason administering oral medications to their pets.

"The Court concluded that Dr. Mason jeopardized the safety of the community, which has been severely harmed by the opioid epidemic, by failing to properly secure and track these drugs," Johnston said. "The Court assessed the maximum penalties in this case. This outcome is the result of the excellent work by the Drug Enforcement Administration (DEA), our office's Affirmative Civil Enforcement and Health Care Fraud Investigative Specialist Tyler E. Japhet, and Assistant United States Attorney Gregory P. Neil."

"DEA registrants are responsible for handling controlled substances responsibly and ensuring complete and accurate records are being maintained in compliance with the Controlled Substance Act," said Special Agent in Charge Jim Scott, head of DEA's Louisville Division. "Failure to comply with controlled substance regulations puts our communities in grave danger, and any registrant who fails to meet these standards will be held accountable."

A copy of this press release is located on the website of the [U.S. Attorney's Office](#) for the Southern District of West Virginia. Related court documents and information can be found on [PACER](#) by searching for Case No. 3:35-cv-175.

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